



GANG RAPE BY FIVE POLICEMEN Delhi

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ACCUSED SHO of Inderpuri Police Station
Pradeep Kumar and four constables

DETAILS Five policemen raped a woman, the wife of a local criminal involved in betting. She was taken to the police station ostensibly for an investigation on her husband.

CURRENT STATUS The police have registered a case of gangrape against the five policemen, but the identification parade is still to be carried out. Following widespread violent protests, the inquiry has been handed over to the Crime Branch and the SHO has been transferred.

Rapists are usually someone the victim knows. They have a history of similar sexual assaults, such as former reserve police constable Umesh Reddy, who was found guilty of over 20 cases of crimes against women, including rape and murder, and was awarded a death sentence by the Karnataka High Court in February after an 11-year-long judicial process. They also feel powerful in gangs, as the assaults in Surat and Mumbai show. A gangrape has initiators who want all those who are witness to the crime to be party to it, so no one can

report the matter, and they have followers, whom they force to participate. That's what happened in 2005 when six men gang-raped a 16-year-old girl in a DTC bus parked at a depot near Najafgarh in Delhi. Here two of the rapists took the lead; mercilessly beat up the girl as they raped her, while one of them was actually forced to assault her, despite pleading with the others to stop.

Most rapists are found to prefer certain professions that allow them access to unsuspecting victims. It could be a teacher, doctor, administrator in institutions

such as orphanages or even a spiritual guru. Take the case in Delhi in 2003 when a 54-year-old doctor, married with two daughters, was arrested for having sex with a 13-year-old patient who had come to him for treatment of tuberculosis at a posh private nursing home in Vasant Vihar while her aunt waited outside. In 2007, a 44-year-old married private tutor in East Delhi bluffed a 17-year-old girl into having oral sex with him to help increase her concentration just before raping her. This year in February a 15-year-old girl was allegedly held captive for two days and raped by her teacher, Ajit Kumar Singh, in Faizabad, in Uttar Pradesh. As Mumbai-based psychiatrist Harish Shetty says, no one is safe. "Anyone in power will target the vulnerable in this globalised world."

Is it any surprise then that India, in the midst of a frenetic social flux, should be one of the nations most unsafe for women, topped only by the US and South Africa, according to 2008 data from the Ministry of Home Affairs, even though Nagpal estimates that only a quarter of the sexual harassment cases are actually reported. It's also no surprise that rape is one of the fastest growing crimes in India, with the number of rapes a day rising from seven in 1971, when such cases were first recorded by the NCRB, to 57 now, a leap of 800 per cent. In comparison, all other crimes have grown by 300 per cent since 1953 when the NCRB started keeping records.

Rape in India can become communal, as the Surat gangrape showed

where the perpetrators were young Muslim boys, who were attacked by enraged people at the city hospital where they were taken for a medical check-up by the police. It can also be political, as happened in Shopian in Jammu and Kashmir when the bodies of 22-year-old Neelofar Jan and her 17-year-old sister-in-law Asiya were fished out of a *nullah*. It is always inhuman. And planned with cold-blooded precision, where psychological dominance is often preferred to brute force. Sometimes such persuasion becomes easier when there is already a relationship of trust, as in 2007 when a 17-year-old was raped by her 21-year-old cousin in Ghaziabad. He bided his time, nurturing her emotionally, helping her

